

Photographs by K. M. KISHAN



**CONTRACTOR AJAY KUMAR JHA ENJOYS POLICE PROTECTION (LEFT); THE GOVERNMENT FOOTS THE SECURITY BILLS OF VISHAL SINGH (BELOW), SON OF JD(U) MP MEENA SINGH**

payment of cost made by him for the simple reason that a police personnel is deputed as security guard at the risk of life and property of other citizens". Advocate M.P. Gupta of Patna High Court is convinced that letting private individuals avail free government security is incongruent with the high court order.

Some of the private individuals, who either availed or are still availing free government protection are Vijay Gupta (owner of a *dal* mill in Rohtas), Ajay Kumar Jha (a contractor who unsuccessfully contested an Assembly bypoll on a BJP ticket), Moolchanda Golchha (a businessman in Araria who has two bodyguards), contractor Samar Singh (Araria), businessman Ganesh Narayan Bedia in Bhojpur and contractor Sahdev Kanaodiya in Banka (now withdrawn).

The replies from various districts also reveal a new trend of VIPs as many elected members of Panchayati Raj institutions now enjoy all expenses-paid government protection. Though authorities in some districts have of late ordered withdrawal of free government bodyguards from some private individuals, nothing has been done to make them pay for the police protection they had for months, and in some cases, more than a year.

These specifics have surfaced in response to an RTI application which was submitted seeking information on the number of police bodyguards made available to private persons in Bihar. The application was filed before the State Home Department on October 3, 2008. In fact, it was on October 13, 2009, when Joint Secretary (Home) Dharendra Mohan Jha provided the last piece of information to INDIA TODAY, taking well over a year to furnish complete details.

Clearly, the Home Department's delay almost defeated the basic tenet of the RTI Act, 2005, which states that the public information officer shall, as expeditiously as possible, provide the information or reject the request. The

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Government bodyguards in Bihar have often shown that they are willing to bend a few rules while supporting the unlawful activities of their masters (read the VIPs). The arrest of constable Umesh Singh, the bodyguard of JD(U) leader Vijay Krishna, for his alleged involvement in the abduction and murder of builder Satyendra Kumar Singh is a case in point. Earlier the bodyguard of former RJD MP Sadhu Yadav was

found allegedly manhandling an IAS officer, besides creating disturbance at polling booths. The bodyguard of former minister Lalit Yadav was found absconding with the former minister when they were charged with illegally detaining and torturing a truck driver. In 2007, two police bodyguards of former Siwan MP Mohammad Shahabuddin were convicted for their involvement in the attack on a superintendent of police.

ing for the government security.

For instance, two police bodyguards, Udai Singh and Chhotan Kumar Singh, have been deputed to Vishal Singh, the son of JD(U) MP Meena Singh. The Government foots his security bills. According to the Rohtas SP, Vishal faces a threat to his

life from "anti-social elements".

A Patna High Court order of 2005, delivered by a division bench of then Acting Chief Justice Nagendra Rai and Justice S.N. Hussain, states that "in case any person having sufficient means applies for the security then the security should be provided to him on